



C e r e a l

Prom Night

-by Cory Reeve

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Carrie sighed and sank down into her seat. The dark gray Acura NSX slid through the night with quiet power. She looked out through the darkly tinted window and watched the trees rush by.

Next to her, Andrew reached up to the dashboard and turned down the radio, which had been screaming Nine Inch Nails. "What's on your mind?" he said in his deep, rich voice. "You seem distracted."

Carrie looked over at him and smiled. "I was just thinking about how wonderful tonight has been," she told him, the smile still stretched across her face. "I'm really glad that you came back from college to go to my prom with me."

"Not a problem," he said, eyeing the road as they approached a sharp curve. "I was actually hoping that you would ask me."

Carrie smiled, moonlight shimmering in her eyes. She had been planning on asking him ever since she went to his prom the year before. Even before she learned about what had happened to him during the school year, she had been intent on asking him. "I'm glad. I just can't get over how much fun I've had tonight."

The corner of Andrew's mouth curled up, and even though she felt strongly for him, and despite her self-confidence, she did not like the look in his eye. "Yeah, and the night is nowhere *near* over."

The tone of his voice made her shiver in spite of herself. *Don't lose your cool now, girl.* But she definitely did not feel safe when he spoke those words. Not at all.

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The night was clear and warm. Carrie enjoyed the light breeze which was blowing through her hair. Behind her, there was a brief flash of parking lights and a light honk of the horn as Andrew engaged the Acura's alarm. "Beautiful, isn't it?" he asked as he strode up to stand next to her.

"Yes," she said; her voice was slow and soft, most of her attention enraptured by the beauty of the scene before her.

They were standing next to a pavilion bordering a small lake. Pale moonlight shimmered down through a cloudless sky and glittered off the still water. Cattails pierced the water a short distance from the shore and to the left. The soft rippling sound of reeds in the light breeze was very relaxing.

Strong hands gripped her shoulders and turned her around gently. Carrie looked up into Andrew's pale, gray eyes. All resistance ran out of her when she looked into his irises, glimmering in the moonlight. He leaned forward and kissed her full on the lips.

The combined effect of the look and then his kiss was too much for her, and Carrie melted into his arms. Gently, he lowered her to the ground. He stripped her out of her dress and threw it back behind him. It fluttered lightly in the breeze and settled onto the hood of the car. He stood up and began to undress. As he did this, Carrie took off her underwear.

While she was working at the clasp of her bra, one of her fingers slid off and clicked down on a small button sewn into the fabric of the bra. A small red light flickered to life and began to blink steadily at regular three-second intervals. She finished unhooking the bra and tossed it so it landed on the hood of the car.

When they were both undressed completely, Andrew approached where she was lying on the ground and bent over her. Carrie placed her hands on his shoulders. "I've been waiting for this for a long time," she said, and then pulled him down to her.

Behind them, on the hood of the car, the transmitter in her bra continued to blink its dim, red light.

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When they had finished, Andrew drew back and up. "Now we shall have a bit of time, my sweet," he told her, his voice soft and deep.

She stared deeply into his eyes and all conscious thought drained away from her. All the world consisted of now was Andrew and her. Nothing else mattered. Nothing else even existed. Andrew leaned over her and Carrie was vaguely aware that his mouth was open, and that his incisors appeared to actually be *growing!* His teeth were almost

too large to fit in his mouth.

But that didn't matter. Nothing mattered but the piercing look of his eyes. Carrie has a sense of some strange, alien presence as Andrew's face drew close to her neck. She moaned softly as he opened his mouth wider, and his lips and teeth, far too long for any human mouth, brushed the sensitive skin of her neck.

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Andrew was just about to sink his teeth into Carrie's flesh when his body went completely rigid. He jerked up straight, sitting on his knees. The blunt end of a wooden tent stake appeared to be growing out of his chest. He looked down and Carrie winked up at him. "You should have seen it coming, you fucking bloodsucker," she said in a scolding, motherly tone.

"Your strategy was good," Andrew said, pulling the stake from his chest. "But your aim leaves a little something to be desired."

He brought the stake up in the air, meaning to bring it down into her face. Quickly, she struck out and rammed the heels of her hands into the wound she had just created with the stake. Andrew roared in intense pain. "Yeah, well, I have something that you don't," she spit, accenting the last word with a double-handed blow to his face.

Andrew toppled over on his back, the stake coming loose from his hand. Carrie gained her feet, jumped in the air over him, and grabbed it while doing a forward roll toward the car. She came up on one knee, her long, auburn hair waving in the breeze. The stake was at arm's length behind her; the muscles of her arm were tense, ready to throw it with all her strength.

Slowly, Andrew rose from the ground. He looked like a man getting up after a particularly restful nap. Almost absently, he turned to face her, his eyes now glowing an inhuman red flame. "Is that a fact?" he asked through clenched teeth. His incisors, now extended to the length of demon fangs, hung out over his bottom lip. "And what might this *'something'* of yours be?"

Carrie drew her eyes down in a vicious sneer. Just at that moment the moon passed behind a cloud, plunging the area into a thin veil of darkness. One word floated out of the black and reached Andrew's ears.

"Backup."

Instantly, the night exploded with harsh, white light. Andrew bellowed in pain and rage and stumbled back several steps, trying to shield his face. Three sets of high beams pinned him in a circle of white light like a bug. There were hard clacking sounds as eight shotguns were cocked and aimed. Andrew leaped forward toward them, the vehicle's headlights illuminating him perfectly.

When Carrie saw him, she screamed out loud. This time it was she who staggered back a step. Andrew had turned into something out of a nightmare! In all of her horrible dreams about monsters, goblins, and demons, she had never even imagined anything as hideous as the

creature standing in the light.

The monster's body was twisted and deformed. Rows of sharp, glittering teeth hung out of its jagged scar of a mouth. Red, brutally intelligent eyes gleamed from sockets sunk deep into the beast's oversized head. "You will all die!" the thing roared in a low, rumbling voice. It sounded as if a motorcycle had been given the ability to articulate its exhaust.

At that moment, Carrie's backup opened fire. Shotgun blasts ripped large holes in the terrifying spectre before them. Andrew was continually knocked backward by each successive blow. Finally, after almost a full minute of constant firing, the monster which was Andrew fell over backward.

The firing ceased, smoke rose lazily from the barrels of the shotguns, and Carrie strode up to the bloody, horribly mutilated creature lying on the ground. Andrew looked up at her, his naked body silhouetted by the headlights. She squatted down next to him, the wooden stake in her right hand, and something long and black in the other. "I'm sorry it had to end this way, Andrew," she said softly, then rammed the stake through his left breast and into his heart. He regarded her complacently with his hell-fire eyes. "I don't know if that hurts, but it's enough to completely incapacitate you."

"I was really hoping that you weren't a vampire. You meant a great deal to me when you were human." Her voice sounded reserved and reflective, almost sad. "You should have been more careful when you went off to college. You should have known that it is a great, big, dangerous world out there. I'm just sorry that you had to learn the hard way."

Carrie stood up and gripped the long, black object with both hands. She pulled with her right hand and drew the longsword out of its sheath. Carrie dropped to one knee and drew the sword back, up over her head. "Good-bye, old friend," she said softly.

She brought the sword down with all of her power. She watched as it slipped through the air in its deadly arc. The blade swung closer to her friend's neck and Carrie closed her eyes.

The blade struck true and severed the monster's head with a single, quick stroke. Blood poured from the creature's headless neck, staining the ground a deep black. Carrie stood, turned, and slid the sword back into its sheath. She felt the heat on her back as Andrew's body burst into a column of flame. As she walked back toward the cars, the moon emerged from behind the cloud and bathed the scene in its own pale, white light.

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